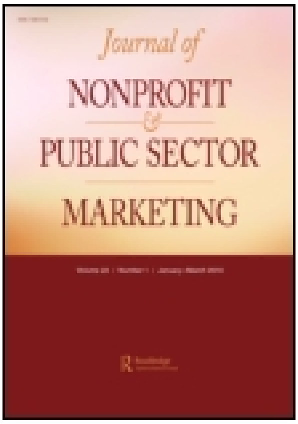

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Building the Charity Brand Community

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Building the Charity Brand Community

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The current article extends the concept of brand community to the charity sector. While the charity sector has begun to embrace the relationship marketing paradigm, brand communities represent a unique form of relationship marketing that can have a significant impact on nonprofits. A conceptual model of brand community development in the charity sector is proposed, and two unique mechanisms by which charity brand communities might develop — the cognitive and experiential-learning mechanisms — are proposed. Not only do these mechanisms offer unique insights into how brand communities might develop, but they also explain how "sense of community" becomes a dominant influence on supporter loyalty. Research propositions concerning the influence of specific markers of brand community upon charity support behavior, are also presented.

KEYWORDS brand community, relationship marketing, nonprofit marketing, charity support behavior

INTRODUCTION

Despite the size and importance of the charity sector to any nation's economy – an estimated $200 billion was donated to charities in the United States alone in 2000 (Lindahl & Conley, 2002) - charities have only recently begun to embrace the marketing concept that their for-profit counterparts have exploited for

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years (e.g. Sargeant, 2001a;, 2001b). That charities have begun to develop marketing strategies is not surprising when one considers the challenges facing the industry and its organizations today: a decline in direct donations (Peacock, 2000; Williamson, 2003), a decline in government support (Hibbert & Horne, 1995), and continued growth in the number of charities looking for funding each year (Liao, Foreman and Sargeant, 2001). Given the highly competitive market facing charities, it is not surprising that the non-profit sector has become more aggressive and creative in its efforts to educate and ultimately attract both individual and corporate donors, volunteers, sponsors and partners. In so doing, the sector has adopted and adapted a wide range of marketing concepts such as: marketing orientation (Sargeant, Foreman, & Liao, 2002); segmentation (Coleman, 2002; Keyt, Yavas, & Riecken, 2002), customer relationship marketing (Thomas, Cunningham & Williams, 2002), and loyalty (Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007). Indeed, much of the recent work in the marketing of charitable organizations has focused on the application of relationship marketing techniques to build donor commitment (Peltier, Schibrowsky & Schultz, 2002; Vandenberg, 1998; Weir & Hibbert, 2000) as a means to increase the lifetime value of supporters (Bennett, 2006).

More recently, the importance and role of branding in the charity sector has received increased attention by researchers (e.g., Hankinson, 2001, 2002; Hoeffler & Keller, 2002) and practitioners, as non-profits begin to explore the latent potential of their own brands. However, charities have struggled with the complexities of managing this valuable resource, and specifically of deciding which organizations to enter into partnerships with. Moreover, charities must also evaluate and select the form of brand relationship that they will have with an external agency: arms length such as the decision to accept donations or sponsorship income, or more intimate such as co-branding, joint branding or licensing (Hoeffler & Keller, 2002, Peloza & Hassay, 2008).

This article extends previous work by exploring a form of relationship marketing shown to lead to almost fanatical loyalty — brand communities (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001) — and the potential for developing brand communities within the charitable sector. To date, the study of brand communities has been largely limited to consumer products, such as: Jeep, Harley-Davidson, Saab, Saturn and Apple Computer (McAlexander, Schouten, & Koenig, 2002; Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). And while applications of the concept to nonprofit organizations such as universities have been studied (McAlexander, Koenig, & Schouten, 2006), the current article represents the first known application of brand community to charitable organizations. Indeed, we believe that successful application of the brand community concept can provide cash-strapped charities with a unique approach to the development and maintenance of supporter commitment.

Beyond extending the brand community concept to the charity sector, this article makes an important contribution to the brand community literature by introducing a conceptual model of brand community development. The proposed model is based on established attitudinal (e.g., identification, perceived sense of community) and behavioral (e.g., involvement) measures and is believed to offer researchers and practitioners valuable insights into the brand community development process. Finally, this article demonstrates the applicability of the proposed model of brand community development to a wide variety of products and services.

The article begins with an overview of the brand community concept. The authors then ground the markers of brand community (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001) within the broader body of consumer commitment literature by conceptually linking these markers to the dominant attitudinal and behavioral constructs within the literature. The article then explores the markers of brand community within the charity sector, and proposes a generic model of brand community development. The article concludes with implications for charities looking to leverage the benefits of brand community, and a discussion of the relevance of the proposed model to other sectors.

BRAND COMMUNITY

The idea of communities developing around consumption extends back to Boorstin (1973) who argued that advertisers have been responsible for the development of "consumption communities" since the civil war. These consumption communities were described as groups of people with feelings of shared well-being, shared risks, common interests and common concerns centered on the consumption of a common object (Boorstin, 1973). Consumption communities have also been referred to as consumption sub-cultures (Shouten & McAlexander, 1995), brand clubs (Langer, 1997) and most recently brand communities (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001).

Recognizing the benefits that accrue from having a loyal customer base (e.g., increased profits), firms have been actively seeking ways to develop and maintain closer relationships with their customers. To this end, there has been considerable scrutiny of products and companies that enjoy above average levels of loyalty from their respective customers, and in some instances a devotion that borders on brand fanaticism. Moreover, firms with a devoted consumer following such as: Harley Davidson, Jeep, Apple Computers and Saturn are often seen to have a highly visible "brand community" (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001) or "brand club" (Langer, 1997). Muniz and O'Guinn (2001) defined the brand community as "a specialized, non-geographically bound community, based on a structured set of social relationships among admirers of a brand" (p.412). A brand community, such as the Harley Owners Group (HOG), is a group of likeminded consumers (e.g., Harley owners) who interact with one another in support of a particular brand (e.g., Harley Davidson motorcycles), and is distinguished from a leisure group (e.g., motorcycle riders club) by its single brand focus. Further, the almost fanatical loyalty of members of brand communities distinguish these communities from other, less intensely experienced buyer clubs such as frequent flier programs and other frequency marketing programs.

Products supported by brand communities have been associated with higher levels of consumer identification and involvement (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001) and with fiercely loyal customers (Lemon, Rust, & Zeithaml, 2001). In addition, it has been reported that manufacturers who actively manage their brand communities have increased market share, increased sales, and increased commitment on the part of consumers (Hoeffler & Keller, 2002; McAlexander et al., 2002). Finally, "brandfests" (McAlexander et al., 2002) such as those employed by Daimler-Chrysler's Jeep Division (e.g., Camp Jeep and Jeep Jamboree) have been associated with increased future purchase intentions of non-owner participants, as well as, the actual repurchase rates of Jeep owners (McAlexander et al., 2002).

Muniz and O'Guinn (2001) identified three markers that contribute to the development and maintenance of brand community: *consciousness of kind*, *shared rituals and traditions*, and a *sense of moral responsibility*. Each of these markers represents a latent state formed by a variety of antecedent processes that Muniz and O'Guinn (2001) identified as mechanisms. For example, *consciousness of kind* refers to the bond that exists between customers of a brand – a close connection that is experienced between customers who may live at great distance from one another and who might not have even met. This connection is commonly defined not in terms of who is "in" but rather, by who is "out," with community members often viewing marginal members and members of competing brand communities with disdain (Shouten & McAlexander, 1995).

Brand communities also feature *shared rituals and traditions* that are embedded in symbols, events, celebrations and activities that are unique to that particular brand and that serve as reminders of what the brand stands for (McAlexander et al., 2002; Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). Thus, shared rituals and traditions require participation or some form of behavioral involvement from the brand community membership. For example, Muniz and O'Guinn (2001) reported that "brand stories" are shared as a way to bind community members, as well as celebrate the history of the brand. Furthermore, these rituals and traditions reinforce group norms and values that define and maintain the culture of the community.

Moral responsibility is viewed as a shared duty amongst the individual members of the community; a set of norms, rules and obligations that help to define and govern group behavior. Thus, moral responsibility is seen as a catalyst for group cohesion and collective action. Two main drivers for moral responsibility are: 1) the integration and retention of members and 2) a concern for the proper consumption of the brand (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001).

In the current article, the three markers of brand community identified by Muniz and O'Guinn (2001) are presented as three components of an iterative, reinforcing process that help to establish and maintain brand commitment. Moreover, we argue that the charity brand community develops by one of two unique processes; one is affectively and attitude-driven and another that is more experiential and behaviorally-driven.

In order to facilitate the development of a generic model of brand community it was necessary to situate the discussion of brand community within the broader context of consumer behavior and within the extant literature on branding and relationship marketing. In order to do so, it was necessary to draw parallels between the markers of brand community introduced by Muniz and O-Guinn (2001) and concepts and constructs that have are not just well-established, but central to the study of relationships within marketing. To this end, Table 1 draws parallels between the three markers of brand community and three central constructs that have a rich history in both the for-profit and nonprofit marketing literatures and for which reliable, valid measurement instruments are already available. Hereafter, the three constructs of *identification, involvement, and perceived sense of community* (PSC) are presented jointly and interchangeably with the

TABLE 1 Brand Community Markers and Proposed Surrogate Measurement Constructs

Brand Community Marker	Definition (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001)	Surrogate Measurement Construct	Definition
Consciousness of Kind	"The intrinsic collective sense that members feel toward one another and the collective sense of difference from others not in the community." (p. 413)	Identification	"Degree to which a person defines him or herself as having the same attributes that he or she believes define the organization." (Dutton, Dukerich, & Harquail 1994, p.239)
Shared Rituals and Traditions	Social processes that reproduce/reinforce the meaning of the community and transmit it to others.	Involvement	"The active interest in, engagement with, and commitment to a [group, sport or product] exhibited by the [individual]." (Capella, 2002, p.31)
Moral Responsibility	"A sense of duty to the community as a whole, and to individual members of the community." (p. 424)	Perceived/ Psychological Sense of Community	"A feeling that members have of belonging, a feeling that members matter to one another and to the group, and a shared faith that members' needs will be met through their commitment to be together." (McMillan & Chavis, 1986, p.9)

three brand community markers of consciousness of kind, rituals and traditions, and moral responsibility.

The study of "sense of community" has a rich history within sociology and psychology as individuals with a strong sense of belonging to the communities in which they live (i.e., neighborhoods) and work (e.g., companies, trade unions) were found to engage in a wide variety of behaviors supportive of these communities. And while the study of consumption communities has grown dramatically in recent years, to date there have only been a few attempts to develop and apply measures of the PSC construct within a marketing context (Friedman, Abeele, & De Vos, 1992, 1993; Fraering & Minor, 2006) and none within a charity or nonprofit sector. And while not yet widely used in marketing and consumption contexts, it is argued that due to its importance to the study of brand community, PSC will become an increasingly the consumer behavior, psychology and organizational behavior literatures (Broderick & Mueller, 1999) and have been shown to be central factors in the development of organizational commitment (Steers, 1977). In fact, Steers (1977) definition of organizational commitment actually includes these two variables and thus offers conceptual support for the proposed model of brand community developed in this article. Researchers have also suggested that brand equity, and the positive outcomes associated with it such as increased satisfaction, patronage and referrals are facilitated by identification (e.g., Fisher & Wakefield, 1998; Gwinner & Swanson, 2003; Underwood, 2003; Underwood, Bond & Baer, 2001). In an extensive review of the involvement construct Broderick and Mueller (1999) indicated that individuals high in involvement, despite their willingness to expend greater energies in the search for and evaluation of information prior to purchase, actually form attitudes that are more resistant to change, and thus are considered to be more brand loyal. These findings offer support for the importance of these particular constructs within the consumer behavior literature, and for our inclusion of these particular constructs in the proposed model of brand community.

The use of these particular constructs allows for the development of research propositions and a model of brand community development that are both theoretically-grounded and empirically testable. Moreover, while the markers of brand community highlight features or aspects of a brand community, they were not intended to capture causality, in fact Muniz and O'Guinn (2001) distinguished these markers of brand community from the "mechanisms" by which brand communities developed. Finally, by conceptualizing the development of brand community with pre-existing constructs the authors propose a model of brand community that is parsimonious, insofar as it purposely avoids introducing novel constructs, and that is both approachable and instructive for both researchers and practitioners.

A PROPOSED MODEL OF BRAND COMMUNITY

The previous sections provide support for the development of brand community within the charity sector, while highlighting the synergistic, iterative relationship amongst the three markers of brand community – shared ritual, consciousness of kind and moral responsibility – as proposed in Figure 1. Moreover, these constructs are hypothesized as self-reinforcing, a product of the iterative nature of the proposed model and the unique mechanisms (i.e., paths) by which brand community is formed. Consistent with this iterative view Schouten and McAlexander (1995) stated that,

> The individual's movement into and through the commitment-based status hierarchy of the HDSC [Harley- Davidson-oriented subculture of consumption] constitutes a gradual transformation of the self … bikers undergo an evolution of motives and a deepening of commitment as they become more involved in the subculture. (p. 55)

And while it is acknowledged that there may be one mechanism that can adequately explain how the majority of people become integrated or

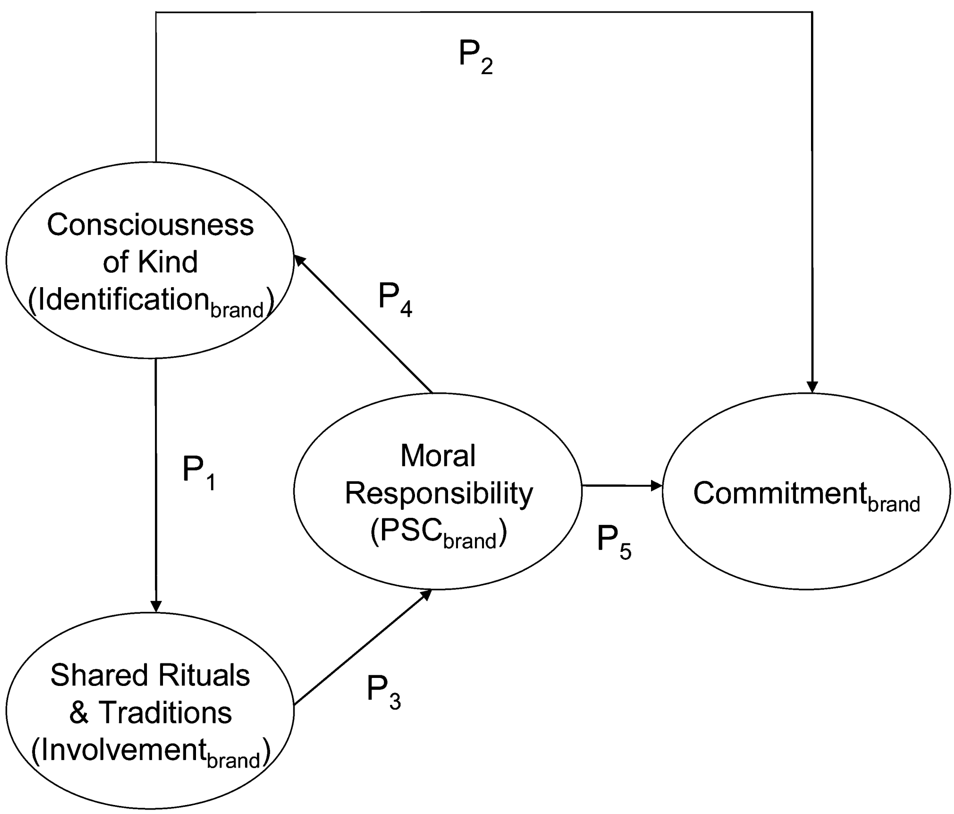

FIGURE 1 Conceptual Model of Brand Community Development

assimilated into a brand community (i.e., through the socialization that begins with behavioral involvement), the proposed model does not account for the temporal relationship between the three markers of brand community. For instance, while some community members will undoubtedly first identify with and then become involved with a brand, as in the case of aspirational consumption (i.e., aspire to the Harley-Davidson lifestyle), others are likely to identify with the brand only after a period of time or series of satisfying experiences with the brand (e.g., attend a Jeep Jamboree). Dwyer, Schurr and Oh (1987) suggested that "exploration" is an important phase in relationship development, and is fragile in the sense that it is characterized by minimal investments and even rational consideration of obligations and benefits of that particular relationship. To this end, McAlexander et al. (2002) indicated that Jeep community members are encouraged to bring friends and family to "Jeep 101" events so that they too can witness the enthusiasm that the Jeep community has for this brand of vehicles.

The proposed model suggests that both consciousness of kind (identification) and shared rituals (behavioral involvement) can lead to the development of moral responsibility (perceived sense of community) and subsequently commitment to a brand or charity. However, we argue that there are two unique mechanisms by which brand communities might develop in a charity brand context. The *cognitive-learning mechanism* is the first to be discussed and echoes the well established view that creating a sense of identity amongst potential supporters is an effective fundraising strategy (Brady, Noble, Utter, & Smith, 2002). In contrast, the second mechanism – the *behavioral learning mechanism* – has received far less attention in the literature and focuses on the means by which "non-identifying" individuals can be attracted, exposed and transformed/converted to loyal charity brand supporters.

Mechanism 1: Brand Community Development through Cognitive-Learning

The cognitive learning mechanism proposes that brand community is develops only after consumers, linked by a common bond of brand passion (identification), increase their participation (behavioral involvement) in brand-supportive activities (see Table 2). This view is consistent with the

TABLE 2 Mechanisms of Brand Community Development

Mechanism	Proposed Model Paths
Cognitive-Learning	Identification → Involvement → Perceived Sense of Community
Behavioral-Learning	Involvement → Perceived Sense of Community → Identification

Brady et al. (2002) finding that giving behavior is influenced by a donor's philanthropic history — a philanthropic predisposition — and that for some giving is learned behavior and/or influenced by referent expectations. Those who have this philanthropic predisposition know that it is important to give and thus identify with the act of giving and the normative responsibility to help or give back. For instance, the wealthy give not just because they can but because they are expected to do so; having been socialized by their parents and peers to give. Indeed, many of the largest supporters of charity give at arm's length through charitable foundations. Warren Buffet giving most of his $31 billion US donation to the *Gates Foundation* is but one, extreme example. The social influence strategy of United Way fundraising is also illustrative here, as businesses pledge and give more because others in the business community do so, not necessarily because they are committed to the objectives and goals of the organization.

It is our contention that it is only through increased involvement that individuals and firms move beyond mere giving, and become integrated into the charity brand community. Brady et al. (2002) support this argument, suggesting that charitable organizations should be encouraging regular, consistent donations rather than attempting to secure large, one-time donations in an attempt to develop a philanthropic disposition that may evolve into a long-term relationship and perhaps spread to the donor's referent group.

Peloza and Hassay (2007) developed a typology of *Charity Support Behavior* (CSB) that presents a broad spectrum of high and low involvement forms of support. In this typology Peloza and Hassay (2007) clearly delineate activities which require little thought, are easy to do (e.g., donation) and which are commonly motivated by reasons external to the charity (e.g., tax benefits, get rid of the asker), from those that require greater effort, and stronger ties to the charity (e.g., volunteering). However, what is most compelling about this typology is that it also identifies CSBs (e.g., charity events, volunteering) that: a) are more likely to establish social bonds between supporters, the charity and non-supporters and, b) will be sought by more highly identified individuals. Participation in experiential events such as *Days of Caring*, fun runs, the *Weekend to End Breast Cancer* leads to the development of social ties with likeminded others, ties that ultimately lead to the development of a heightened sense of moral responsibility (PSC) to others in the community.

Figure 1 also suggests that PSC, once developed, serves to reinforce positive brand attitudes (identification) and leads to greater commitment to the brand "sponsoring" or associated with that event or ritual. For example, while attitudes towards the brand increase, community participants also experience a concomitant negativity towards competing brands. In fact, community members often use derogatory terms to describe competing brands even indicating a willingness to forego product category participation (e.g., motorcycles) rather than switch brands (McAlexander et al., 2002;

Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). Further support for the reinforcing role that community participation has upon identification is offered by Algesheimer, Dholakia and Herrmann (2005) who found that knowledgeable and therefore arguably more involved consumers of a particular automotive brand were found to be more identified with the brand community they belonged to (e.g., car club) than their novice counterparts.

Additionally, McAlexander, Kim and Roberts (2003) have reported that while brand community integration (BCI) has a positive influence on loyalty amongst those who have been engaged in a relationship for an extended period, satisfaction does not. This finding supports a growing body of research that suggests that satisfaction has a short-term effect on loyalty. Put another way satisfaction, may be perceived as a threshold construct, insofar as individuals must be satisfied to engage in a relationship but it is insufficient to sustain a relationship. In contrast, BCI appears to capture a deeper connection between an individual and a brand – an affective bond that integrates both social capital and camaraderie (Fraering & Minor, 2006). Once established, moral responsibility (PSC) is seen to have both a direct and an indirect – by positively influencing consciousness of kind (identification) – influence on commitment.

Mechanism 2: Brand Community Development through Experiential-Learning

In the first mechanism, it is assumed that an individual identifies with a charity or cause and through subsequent actions made on behalf of the charity becomes immersed in that charity's brand community. The experiential learning mechanism (see Table 2) offers a different view, suggesting that an individual's identity with a charity develops as a result of participation in and consumption of CSBs (Peloza & Hassay, 2007). In this mechanism, behavioral involvement is the catalyst for brand community development. More importantly, it is our contention that it is the social interaction between the charity and potential and existing supporters that occurs at brandfests (e.g., fun runs, charity events), and other forms of high-involvement CSBs, that is ultimately responsible for brand community development. This particular mechanism mirrors the process of "transformation" process witnessed within the Harley Davidson sub-culture (HDSC: Shouten & McAlexander, 1995). Specifically, Shouten and McAlexander (1995) identified three stages by which consumers experience the transformational process in the HDSC: "(1) experimentation with the biker identity, (2) identification and conformity, and (3) mastery and internalization" (p.55). It is argued that these three transformational stages are analogous to the involvement, PSC and identification constructs of the experiential learning mechanism.

This particular mechanism is especially important to brand community development because it accounts for new member socialization; an important dimension of moral responsibility according to Muniz and O'Guinn (2001). And as McAlexander et al. (2002) illustrated, some Jeep Jamboree participants did not even own a Jeep prior to attending the event, and yet, as a result of their involvement, became brand believers with an express desire to purchase a Jeep. Thus, this brand community development process follows an experiential path to attitude formation, one that is under-researched and yet arguably more representative of how identity formation occurs.

Regardless of the mechanism by which brand community is developed, participation in and identification with a brand community is hypothesized to lead to higher levels of brand commitment and ultimately, behavioral loyalty. As demonstrated by McAlexander et al. (2002) in the brand community literature, and by Morgan and Hunt (1994) in the relationship marketing literature, committed consumers or exchange partners indicate greater willingness to repeat purchase and engage in pro brand support behaviors, such as word of mouth. Therefore, brand community is seen to have a positive effect upon continued brand involvement, which is the intended goal of relationship marketing efforts. Furthermore, brand community is seen to reinforce and elevate existing levels of brand commitment both directly and indirectly through identification.

BRAND COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT IN THE CHARITY SECTOR

Although brand communities have been associated with higher levels of consumer identification and involvement (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001), it is believed that a certain level of product category involvement and/or identification exists prior to community participation and is necessary before any kind of community can be encouraged. This assertion would explain, in part, why discussions of brand community in the literature have thus far focused on relatively expensive, durable goods such as cars, motorcycles and computers (e.g., McAlexander et al., 2002; Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). Not surprisingly then, there have been few explorations of brand communities in low involvement product categories such as routine household food purchases (cf. Broderick & Mueller, 1999). However, this is not to suggest that brand communities or clubs are the exclusive domain of expensive, durable goods as demonstrated by the recent study of the Nutella community by Cova and Pace (2006).

Another, noteworthy exception is the Swatch brand of watches and the membership of that brand's *Swatch Collectors Club* (Long & Schiffman, 1997), and its online community *Swatch the Club*. Although relatively inexpensive, this particular brand of watches enjoys a very active consumer following because of its innovative, fashion forward image and its collectible designs. Particularly germane to the current article was the Long and Schiffman (1997) assertion that Swatch collectors identify with other collectors and receive social benefits from interacting with collectors, dealers and other swatch experts.

As a result, we argue that involvement and identification are the key drivers of brand community; two constructs that have also been shown to be critical indicators of donor commitment to charitable causes (Rosenblatt, Cusson, &McGown, 1986; Smith, 1980). Fisher and Ackerman (1998), for example, argued that the decision to volunteer represents an important, even 'life-altering' commitment. Similar to the outcomes associated with "communities of participation" (Schervish & Havens, 1997), the creation of a charity brand community is expected to lead to increased donor and volunteer commitment. Moreover, it is believed that a vibrant charity community will attract new supporters to events and initiatives that encourage involvement and allow for identification.

Product-focused brand communities form to support the use, display and/or celebration of a tangible product, what Shouten and McAlexander (1995) referred to as a consumption "icon." In fact, Shouten and McAlexander (1995) stated that Harley-Davidson motorcycles have become, "a religious icon around which an entire ideology of consumption is articulated" (p.50). Conversely, charities as service organizations lack a focal product or icon that is at the center of product-based brand community research (e.g., McAlexander et al., 2002; Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). Rather, charity communities form in support of an intangible — the charity's central mission or goal (i.e., to improve education, find a cure, bring happiness or to ease suffering). In a charitable organization, the "product" is the act of taking one's time and/or money and ensuring that it is used for the purpose intended (Guy & Patton, 1988). And yet, there are a variety of "products" consumed in support of charities (e.g. t-shirts, pins); products that provide a similar type of conspicuous consumption experience as those associated with for-profit communities such as Harley-Davidson and Saturn (Aaker, 1994; Reid, 1989). In summary, it is believed that the strong emotional connection that individuals have with charity brands (Rothschild, 1979) provides a fertile medium in which to explore and ultimately cultivate brand community.

The remainder of this section explores the relevance of the three constructs of brand community — consciousness of kind, shared ritual and moral responsibility — within the charity sector.

Consciousness of Kind (Identification)

Underwood et al. (2001) indicated that some customers enjoy relationships with brands that extend beyond the satisfaction of functional needs to a strong, even zealous emotional attachment. Indeed in a later article, Underwood (2003) argued that the consumption of brands, through either lived or mediated experiences, not only strengthens that consumer's relationship with the brand, but can also enhance his/her own self-identity. Underwood et al. (2001) presented social identity as a "mechanism for tapping the emotional connection between the consumer and the service brand. Similarly, Wann and Branscombe (1993) defined team identification in terms of the level of attachment or concern held by an individual towards a particular sports team. In fact, consistent with Muniz and O'Guinn's (2001) discussion of consciousness of kind, Underwood et al. (2001) commented that:

> Social identity affects individuals' perceptions, cognitions, evaluations, and attributions about issues and events, impacting emotions as well as behaviors. Heightened group identification marks in-group/out-group boundaries, facilitating the categorization of people into "us" vs. "them" and "we" vs. "they." (p.3)

The definition of identification by Dutton, Dukerich, & Harquail (1994) that is used in the current article (see Table 1), underscores the idea that individuals identify with people and things with which they share similar attributes. And according to the previous comment by Underwood et al. (2001), attributes can be broadly construed as any common feature between two parties. A related construct, "shared values" (Morgan & Hunt, 1994) was defined as the extent to which partners have beliefs in common about the importance of goals and behaviors. This particular construct is important to the current discussion because Morgan and Hunt (1994) found that shared values are an antecedent of both relationship commitment and trust. Moreover, the importance of having and communicating shared values is underscored in the charity sector, as most charities exist because of a single goal-oriented focus: a cure for a medical condition or disease, the completion of a building project, increased knowledge or a solution to a social problem.

Researchers have highlighted identification or a sense of "we-ness," as a motivation for caring behavior (Schervish & Havens, 1997) and charities have the potential to realize significantly higher levels of identification than those products/service categories associated with the typical product community. For instance, Bhattacharya (1998) suggested that paid membership in non-profit organizations is motivated by a greater sense of affiliation and reciprocity than the clubs and organizational memberships typically found in the private sector. Additionally, it has been suggested that active participation in a charity community is largely motivated by altruism and a shared belief in the goal of helping others, as well as a reliance on others in the community to achieve that goal (see Smith, 1980 for a review).

Moreover, helping the organization increases a member's readiness to categorize and define him/herself as a member of that particular social group (Bhattacharya, 1998). By increasing their support for the organization, through active participation, supporters of a charity are by default increasing their commitment to the donor community. In addition, it is believed that those who are active supporters of the community are more likely to extend their support beyond participation in sanctioned events, to direct contributions to the charity itself (e.g. donations, volunteering). Schlegelmilch, Love and Diamantopoulos (1997), for instance, found that those who engage in volunteer activities are more likely to increase financial commitments as well.

Finally, disidentification has been found to be a powerful motivator for charitable giving, whereby people define themselves in terms of what they are against rather than what they are for. For example, fifty-eight percent of donors say they are involved in philanthropy in order to stand up against people or groups whose agenda they oppose (Fund Raising Management, 1999c). Bhattacharya and Elsbach (2002), indicated that People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals (PETA) benefit from the process of both identification (i.e., I am a proponent of humane treatment of animals) and disidentification (i.e., I am against the fur industry) in terms of generating support.

In addition, certain types of charitable organizations are associated with higher levels of identification. For example, it has been found that reducing the tax advantages associated with charitable giving leads to a decline in donations to some, but not all, charities (Smith, 1980; Smith & Alcorn, 1991). Smith (1980) argued that any increase in the real cost of giving could see gifts to hospitals and educational institutions reduced by as much as half, whereas donations to religious groups might only decrease slightly. Religious charities tend to fair better in harsher economic environments due to the high levels of identification that supporters have with these organizations (Fund Raising Management, 1999b).

Support for charities is often generated through requests from individuals already associated with the giver. For instance, prosocial behavior is shown to increase when the help is solicited by someone from within an individual's social network (Bendapudi, Singh & Bendapudi, 1996). In addition, an individual is also more likely to help if he/she is aware of others like him/herself who also help (Guy & Patton, 1988). In fact, the similarity-attraction paradigm is seen to be very important to social identification and/or kinship development amongst members of a charity group or fundraising event (Hoeffler & Keller, 2002). Specifically, people are more inclined to help those who they consider to be like themselves, regardless of whether they are offering assistance to the actual person in need or a charity intermediary.

Identification with a cause has even been shown to extend to the type of products that supporters buy. For example, consumers have been shown to actively search for and purchase products that support causes that they identify with (Barone, Myazaki & Taylor, 2000; File & Prince, 1998). In addition, Sen and Bhattacharya (2001) found that consumers not only select products based on charity affiliation but that they will even pay more for products affiliated with personally relevant charities (Sen & Bhattacharya, 2001). Conversely, shoppers have also been known to boycott or disidentify with certain brands because of their charity affiliations (Webb & Mohr, 1998). Webb and Mohr (1998) argued that segments of the population invest time and effort, as well as money, to develop informed responses to corporate cause-related marketing initiatives.

Consequently, identification underscores the notion that people who support a cause do not necessarily identify with it, while those who identify with a cause will support it (Bhattacharya, Rao & Glynn, 1995). Furthermore, identification is seen to extend to the consumption of products sold by the charity (mugs, shirts, etc.) as well as the products and services of third parties (e.g., cause-related marketing). In fact, according to Bennett and Gabriel (2000) these purchases provide supporters with a more visible, symbolic statement about their identification with the organization and or cause. Moreover, these purchases are often used as "badges" that allow supporters to define themselves in public.

Undoubtedly, the best examples of consciousness of kind are exhibited by those charities aligned with religious groups. In fact, the religious organization might be viewed as the archetypal consumption (i.e., brand) community. Each religious assembly, order, sect, tribe or congregation has at its core a set of deeply rooted values that are shared by its membership. Members, or parishioners, also hold beliefs and engage in behaviors that foster an in-group versus out-group mindset. In fact, the practice and participation in traditions and rituals can foster intense loyalty and devotion because they create physical and/or emotional barriers to entry and exit. For example, various rites of passage such as baptism, confirmation and circumcision represent an educational and/or physical commitment that precludes conversion (i.e., brand switching) for most members.

Albeit far less dramatic and far less sacrificial; there is empirical support for the proposed relationship between identification and involvement. For example, Fisher and Wakefield (1989) revealed that group identification (e.g., with a professional sports team) had a strong positive effect on various forms of behavioral involvement, such as participation in group activities (e.g., game attendance), the purchase of group relevant products (e.g., licensed merchandise) and other group-supportive behaviors (e.g., game behaviors). Similarly, Sheth and Parvatiyar (1995) proposed that based upon a desire to be identified as well as to identify with a group, individuals will adopt the behavioral norms of that group. In another study, Gwinner and Swanson (2003) found that highly identified sports fans are also more willing to support organizations that sponsor their sport or favourite team. For instance, Gwinner and Swanson (2003) cite research which suggests that NASCAR fans are extremely loyal to companies that support this particular race series. Subsequent studies in the sports and leisure (e.g., Laverie & Arnett, 2000; Wann & Branscombe, 1990) and marketing literatures (e.g., Bristow & Sebastian, 2001) have similarly supported the existence of a relationship between identification with a team or group and subsequent or continued support for that group. Thus, extending these findings to the charity sector we propose that:

> $\mathbf{P_1}$: Supporters with higher levels of consciousness of kind (identification) with a charity will exhibit higher levels of participation in shared rituals (behavioral involvement) with that charity.

Ashforth and Mael (1989) suggested that social identification occurs when an individual perceives him/herself as psychologically intertwined with the fate of the group and organizational identification is believed to be a strong predictor of participation in the charity donor community. For example, a lack of organization identification has been found to be related to lapsed memberships in nonprofit organizations (Bhattacharya, 1998). Similarly, Bristow and Sebastian (2001) reported that "die-hard" Chicago Cubs baseball fans also scored higher on a general measure of loyalty toward this particular team. Thus, it is proposed that identification is a good predictor of a member's expected tenure or length of commitment to a given community.

Therefore, while the current article proposes that the identification has an indirect effect upon commitment through involvement. It also has a direct effect on commitment. In part the existence of a direct effect is predicated on the fact that not all brands have communities and yet the benefit from committed consumers. Thus, the proposed model of brand community recognizes that while brand communities serve to strengthen consumer identification with, and involvement in, brands there can be loyalty or commitment to brands without such communities. For instance, drawing upon research from sociology, psychology and consumer behavior, Kleine posited that the "more a student identifies with being a marketing major, the more committed he or she will be to enacting behaviors that lead to success as a marketing student (p15). Here we see that identification is seen to lead to commitment (Proposition 2) and that in turn this commitment will lead to increased group-supportive behaviors (e.g., participating in marketing clubs) or involvement; a relationship to be discussed in Proposition 3).

Alternatively, just as the act of supporting a charity might not result in an individual identifying with that particular charitable organization or its supporters; mere association or membership (i.e., being a graduate from a particular university) in an organization is not synonymous with commitment to the organization (Bhattacharya & Elsbach, 2002) and is certainly not sufficient to motivate philanthropic action. Rather, donor identification with the organization or cause requires a more developed type of engagement that evolves from the socialization process; socialization that occurs in the "communities of participation" selected by an individual (Lindahl & Conley, 2002).

Therefore, while the vast majority of the public supports some charity or other (Sullivan, 2002), not all supporters of a given charity are prospective members of that charity brand community, just as not every Jeep owner is a member of its brand community. For example, some people give to charities simply to get rid of the person asking (Hibbert & Horne, 1996). The charity sector relies heavily "on the kindness of strangers" and few organizations can afford the luxury of being exclusionary. In fact, charities are seen to be considerably less "judgmental" than the typical consumption community that has product ownership as a condition of membership (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). As a result, charities experience considerable supporter "churn" as a result of transient or episodic support activity what might be referred to as a kind of situational involvement (Laverie & Arnett, 2000). Akin to brand switchers, these transient supporters lack commitment; while they visit the community they fail to become engaged and achieve member status. Given the funding challenges faced by charities, it is critical that they develop and maintain increased loyalty and commitment from supporters. Thus, attracting and maintaining supporter commitment is seen as critical for this sector.

As a result, it is proposed that:

> **P$_2$**: Supporters exhibiting higher levels of consciousness of kind (identification) with a charity will exhibit greater commitment to that charity.

Brand Commitment

Morgan and Hunt (1994) identified commitment as a key mediating variable on important relationship outcomes in marketing such as intent to stay and acquiescence, a role that has been supported in a variety of different contexts. For instance, Fullerton (2003) recently found commitment, and in particular the affective form of commitment had a positive impact on behavioral loyalty (e.g., advocacy intentions, willingness to pay more, switching intentions). Inwasaki and Havitz (2004) recently reported that psychological commitment — defined as the degree to which an individual's attitudes towards a brand are resistant to change — had a positive influence on behavioral loyalty (i.e., duration or frequency of participation). In a study that is particularly germane to the current context, Gruen, Summers, and Acito (2000) found that commitment had a positive effect upon the relationship activities of members in a professional association. Specifically, Gruen et al. (2000) found that member commitment was associated with increased participation in (e.g., meeting attendance) and coproduction of (e.g., attracting new members) association activities.

The proposed relationship between commitment and behavioral intentions (e.g., loyalty) is well supported in the literature (Fullerton, 2003; Gruen et al., 2000; Morgan & Hunt, 1994). Indeed, as Fullerton (2003) acknowledges most conceptualizations of commitment now include at least an attitudinal and behavioral component. Affective commitment is commonly associated with liking and identification, while continuance commitment is typically viewed from a reward (e.g., availability of comparable alternatives) or cost (e.g., switching costs) perspective (Fullerton). Whereas affective commitment captures one's desire to retain ties with an object (e.g., brand) or entity (e.g., organization), continuance commitment embodies the notion that one cannot afford to sever the relationship or is better off maintaining the relationship. Thus most definitions of commitment include an element of relationship continuity as demonstrated by Morgan and Hunt (1994) who defined relationship commitment as a desire to "maintain" a relationship and Dwyer et al. (1987) who viewed commitment as a pledge of continuity.

Consequently, it is proposed that:

> **P_3**: Supporters exhibiting higher levels of commitment to a charity will exhibit greater participation in the shared rituals and traditions of that charity (e.g., behavioral involvement).

Shared Rituals and Traditions (Behavioral Involvement)

Although "involvement" has a rich tradition in the marketing and consumer behavior literature most authors have adopted a more passive view of the construct than the one used here. For instance, while Zaltman and Wallendorf (1983) defined involvement as "a motivational state of mind (arousal) that is goal directed" (p.550), the current article adopts a more experiential or behavioral view of involvement. And thus, within the current context behavioral involvement shares much with constructs such as: behavioral loyalty (e.g., Iwasaki & Havitz, 2004), coproduction (e.g., Gruen et al., 2000; Sheth & Parvatiyar, 1995), customer advocacy (e.g., Fullerton, 2003), customer/organizational citizenship behavior (e.g., Lengnick-Hall, Claycomb & Inks, 2000), customer voluntary performance (e.g., Bettencourt, 1997), group supportive behaviors (e.g., Fisher & Wakefield, 1998) and participation (e.g., Gruen et al., 2000).

We adopt this behavioral view of involvement for a number of reasons. First, and perhaps most importantly, the shared rituals and traditions marker of brand community identified by Muniz and O'Guinn (2001) embodies action in the form of virtual (as in the case of online communities) or face-to-face interaction of consumers, or the consumer's private interaction with the product. Thus, this particular marker is a behavioral construct. Second, researchers have found that the relationship between involvement (the attitudinal construct) and action is rather tenuous, with involvement explaining very little variation in constructs such as behavioral loyalty. For example, Iwasaki and Havitz (2004) were able to show that *enduring involvement* had no direct effect on loyalty, but rather an indirect relationship through psychological commitment. In the aforementioned study, Iwasaki and Havitz (2004) defined leisure involvement as people's beliefs and attitudes about leisure participation. Finally, it is argued that it is the relational outcomes of brand community that are important to the firms and organizations that attempt to build such communities. For instance, increased patronage, increased advocacy, willingness to purchase licensed goods and a willingness to pay more for the brand are all viewed as positive behaviors (Capella, 2002). To this end, we adopt a view of involvement which is consistent with Capella (2002) who defined sports fan involvement as, "the active interest in, engagement with and commitment to a sports team exhibited by the sports fan" (p.31).

Brandfests (McAlexander & Shouten, 1998; McAlexander et al., 2002) associated with Jeep (e.g., Camp Jeep, Jeep Jamboree), Harley Davidson (e.g., HOG rallies) and Saturn (e.g., Homecoming) are the very embodiment of brand community. In fact, according to McAlexander et al. (2002) these communal events have played a central role in the study of the brand community phenomenon to this point. The importance of the brandfest to community development was illustrated by McAlexander et al. (2002) who found that participants were transformed by their participation in such events. Specifically, these authors found that consumers had more favorable perceptions of the brand and were more likely to view themselves as being "in" the brand community after the brandfest experience.

In their study of service brand building, Underwood et al. (2001) commented on the importance of "lived experiences" (e.g., behavioral involvement) to customer-based brand equity. Specifically, Underwood et al. (2001) stated that participation in group events that build inter-consumer (i.e., sports fans) associations, such as tailgate parties and booster clubs help to foster and sustain brand associations. Moreover, Underwood et al. (2001) argued that these experiences need not be live (e.g, face-to-face) to be lived, citing fans can experience similar brand associations and identification via broadcast. Involvement or participation in such group events (e.g., tailgate parties, brandfests) then becomes an important way to share in and preserve a collective identity (e.g., Chicago Cub Fan).

In charitable organizations with well-developed communities both public and private rituals and traditions can be identified. Public rituals and traditions can be seen everywhere; the wearing of poppies in early November, the Salvation Army's Red Kettle Campaign in stores and on street corners at Christmas time, and the Cancer Society's Daffodil Days are but a few examples. Of relevance to the current article is the fact that "participation effects" (i.e., an individual's involvement in religious and voluntary group activities) have been shown to be correlated to charity support (Jackson, Bachmeier, Wood, & Craft, 1995).

Although not exactly the same, there are striking similarities between the kinds of events hosted by religious groups and charitable organizations and the brandfests associated with Saturn and Jeep. In fact Underwood et al. (2001) used the term *events* to describe the identification–building activities of manufacturers such as Jeep and Harley-Davidson. Similar to these brands, a charity brandfest will often involve people coming together to celebrate their communal consumption of the charity "product" (the dispersion of funds toward the cause). To this end, many charity brandfests are predicated on the introduction and mingling of supporters to and beneficiaries of a charity. There are also support groups that enable the affected individual and/or their families to gather to share their experiences and to help those who have recently been diagnosed with a wide variety of spiritual, emotional and physical issues.

Consequently, *event marketing* is employed heavily by charities, with many organizations using the technique as the cornerstone of their fundraising efforts. Participants are actively involved and very committed to these events (e.g. Multiple Sclerosis Bike-A-Thon) giving freely of their time not only at the event, but also prior to it (i.e. organizing, seeking pledges), a commitment that is demonstrated through continued participation each and every year the event is held. Although the event itself (e.g., Jerry Lewis's Telethon for MD) may be a highly ritualized (i.e., every Labor Day) tradition, there is also evidence of shared rituals and traditions that occur within these events (e.g., poster child, updating the contribution tally) and within the daily operation of the organization (e.g., meetings begun with a prayer).

Many charities also foster traditions as they recognize distinguished supporters such as long term volunteers or donors. In fact, Bhattacharya, Rao and Glynn (1995) noted that differing levels of involvement and identification exist within groups of charity supporters. Essentially, there are those who have higher "status" because of their degree of commitment (e.g., time, money or tenure) to the community. The tradition and ritual surrounding the formal recognition of volunteer and donor commitment plays a significant role in the generation and maintenance of the charity support hierarchy. For example, the presentation and display of pins, badges and plaques to volunteers who have surpassed certain tenure milestones is common in many organizations. Similarly, there is a donor hierarchy that is often established through public displays, such as naming ceremonies, published donor lists and permanent donor walls. In other contexts, supporters receive "gifts" (what some might view as incentives) that vary based on the "level of support" (i.e., amount of donation) pledged. Supporters of public television, for instance, receive "better" gifts with successively higher levels of support.

For some individuals these support hierarchies represent a type of charity meritocracy, where each successive level of achievement serves as a "rite of passage" that imbues the recipient special status within the community. Although previously described as non-judgmental, charities are not without social structure. Indeed most have a very well established participant pecking order similar to that found in other well-documented brand communities (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). While the tradition and ritual surrounding such hierarchies and meritocracies may be an effective way of recognizing community contributions, the practice may also be effective at maintaining membership. It is expected that members who participate in these rituals and receive recognition from the charities are more likely to remain loyal and develop a greater sense of communitas.

> **P$_4$**: Supporters who participate in the shared rituals (behavioral involvement) with a charity will exhibit higher levels of a moral responsibility (perceived sense of community) to that charity and those involved with it.

Moral Responsibility (Perceived Sense of Community)

In order to develop a sense of community with an event, cause or organization it is necessary for the new member to first be attracted to and then acculturated to the organization (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). Defined as a shared sense of involvement with others in a group (see Table 1) psychological sense of community (PSC) captures an interpersonal type of attachment that extends beyond mere identification or attraction. Rather, PSC appears to capture the notion of a normative set of beliefs or a responsibility that members of a group have towards one another and the group.

In their study of fan behavior, Laverie and Arnett (2000) examined the influence of "attachment"—a construct which is conceptually similar to the PSC construct introduced here — upon identity salience. Drawing parallels to symbolic consumption Laverie and Arnett (2000) suggested that leisure participation is symbolic and self-expressive and that people become attached to those leisure activities that allow them to express a desired self. Moreover, Laverie and Arnett (2000) commented that, "it is likely that attachment to a leisure activity will be positively related to identity salience" (p. 230). Specifically, these authors found that as fans become more attached to their team their "fan identity" increases. This interaction between attraction and identification is consistent with Proposition 5.

However, Laverie and Arnett (2000) also point out that while the attachment construct has received considerable attention in the product literature it has not often applied to other contexts, such as the attachment people have to sports teams. However, unlike a person's attachment to a sports team, it is our contention that attachment does not fully capture the nature of the relationship that a person has with an organization or group of which they are an actual member. And it is for this reason that we have elected to use PSC – a construct which is more consistent with the kind of interpersonal associations that characterize brand communities.

In the charity sector then, we argue that donors and volunteers have to be made aware of and identify with the mission, if not the organization before they can become involved with a charity brand community. In fact, development of a sense of responsibility and social norms within the community are especially important in the charity sector given that there are relatively few or no switching costs among secular charity brands. Therefore, whereas participation in religious activities is often an integral part of an individual's lifestyle with support for religious charities often a formal requirement of participation and a routine act (e.g. tithing) of many religions. And unlike secular causes, religious charities benefit from having the ability to overtly and not-so-subtly remind members of their obligation to support the church's mission. For example, the primary fundraising initiatives of the Canadian and American Jewish communities — the United and Combined Jewish Appeals — place considerable social pressure upon donors. In addition, publications associated with some religious organizations, specifically prohibits advertising from other "competing" religious charities (e.g., Blair, 1999). Similarly for volunteers, proper "induction" into the organization (i.e. acculturation of the organization's mission, values, etc.) can lead to increased commitment (Wilson & Pimm, 1996). Consequently, we propose that:

> **P_5**: Supporters who exhibit higher levels of moral responsibility (PSC) toward a charity will exhibit higher levels of consciousness of kind (identification) with that charity.

In a review of the literature, it has been found that loyalty – viewed as synonymous with or and outcome of commitment – can be enhanced by the type of social interactions that are associated with brand communities and here the PSC construct. For instance Oliver (1999) has stated that "ultimate loyalty" emerges when the consumer experiences a "convergence of product, personal and social forces" (p. 42). These social forces are at the heart of the brand community phenomenon and have been discussed in services contexts in reference to experiential consumption. For instance, Kelley, Hoffman and Carter (1999) have suggested that it is the "social aspects" of the sports entertainment experience (e.g., hockey) that are essential to long-term fan adoption. Moreover, Kelley et al. (1999) discussed the importance that "community relations" activities have on developing relational bonds between a team and its fans. Consistent with the proposed model of brand community, these authors also described how "thrill performances" (see Deighton, 1992) such as sporting events engage consumers, convincing them to actively participate in the performance (i.e., involvement). Ultimately, Kelley et al. (1999) suggest that through involvement in the social aspects of such events that fans (e.g., a community of supporters) begin to adopt a team.

In the charity sector it has been shown that people prefer to support the CRM programs of companies that do not hop from one charity to the next. For instance, Whitaker (1999) reported that fully eight out of ten people indicating a preference for making a long-term commitment to one cause. Furthermore, CRM efforts that are long term, sustainable and strategic are valued most by supporters of charities (Polonsky & Wood, 2001; Till & Nowak, 2000). The benefits associated with CRM for the recipient charity are typically well-publicized in the promotional and public relations efforts of both the sponsoring organization and the charity. Research shows that "doing good" is also good for business, and marketers have realized sales increases as a result of CRM efforts (Bennett & Gabriel, 2000; Hoeffler & Keller, 2002). However, when inclusion in a group (i.e., charity) is made not by choice, but through a third-party gift (e.g., proceeds from the sale of a Big Mac going to Ronald McDonald House), it is believed that the donor-charity bond will not be sustained unless the donor incorporates the act of donation into his/her sense of self (Bhattacharya, 1998). To this end, the individual must feel some sense of belonging, identification and/or community before he/she can be expected to actively and repeatedly participate.

> $\mathbf{P_6}$: Supporters who exhibit higher levels of moral responsibility (PSC) toward a charity will exhibit higher levels of commitment to the charity.

DISCUSSION AND IMPLICATIONS

For charities, the ability to gain supporter commitment is critical. Despite having been identified as the largest source of potential support in the coming years, today's baby boomers have been shown to be less loyal and more cynical toward non-profits (Fund Raising Management, 1999a) and to support fewer charities than their parents (Fund Raising Management, 1999b). In response, brand communities represent an excellent opportunity to develop and nurture donor and volunteer involvement and identification that will, ultimately, elicit deeper, longer-lasting commitment from supporters and help to attract and engage new supporters as well.

Moreover, this article and its proposed model of brand/charity community development assert that the potential for building such communities is dependent upon the social interaction of consumers and/or supporters. An effective way to encourage social interaction is through the development of ritual and tradition. As discussed, many charities employ event marketing vehicles, but few consciously leverage such events to build supporter commitment by employing ritual and tradition in their event marketing. Given the importance of social interaction to the model proposed in Figure 1, perhaps the most important implication for charities is the need to leverage their existing events in such a way as to create rituals and traditions that foster a perceived sense of community, enhance identification and that encourages them to attend similar events in the future and heed other calls to action (e.g., requests for volunteers, donations).

Thus charities should leverage brandfests to facilitate and encourage member interaction, because these events represent opportunities for members to establish and share common beliefs and experiences, while simultaneously developing a deeper sense of responsibility toward the group. The events can employ the same tactics used by Jeep, Saturn and others and encourage more of a "web" of interaction within and between members of the community. Similar to the way in which members of for-profit brand communities (Jeep, Saturn, etc.) were found to identify with the brand, only after having attended a brandfest, charity brandfests provide an opportunity to convert "participants" into "supporters." This is important because fun runs, concerts and other social events are likely to be attended by large numbers of people who may/may not have previously heard of, let alone identified with the cause or charitable organization. Indeed, it is only through identification and involvement with a community that one can develop anything more than a superficial attachment to it.

In the consumer goods communities discussed, it was shown that a significant event experience often prompted non-members to purchase the product (bought into the cause), thereby becoming full-fledged members (supporters) of that brand's (charity) community. Further, these charity brandfests can themselves become ritualistic behavior. For instance while many charities have ritualized, institutionalized annual events (e.g., Poppy Days, Daffodil Days), they have failed to fully develop strategies for these events that would encourage the kind of supporter-nonsupporter-charity/cause interactions necessary to establish the sense of community discussed within this article.

Within the charity brandfest context there are additional tactics that can be used to encourage consciousness of kind and moral responsibility. By gathering in one location, supporters at least temporarily join a "community," and albeit of relatively short duration there are ways to encourage and support a more deeply experienced sense of communitas. For example, the T-shirts, hats, aprons, pins, flowers and ribbons that are either sold to or provided free of charge, to the volunteers and participants at many events serve as badges that help identify participants as "supporters." In addition, these badges bind participants to other members of the community through a form of conspicuous consciousness of kind. These badges and also extend beyond the event itself as demonstrated by blood donors who receive windshield stickers for their car, and Mothers' Against Drunk Driving (MADD) supporters who place ribbons on their car aerials to publicly display their support for the MADD cause.

Charities can also leverage existing relationships with supporters to foster the development of a brand community. For example, those supporters who are already engaged in cause-related activities and likely identify with it, provide a nucleus for the development of a community. Further, a set of formal/informal role expectations tend to dictate individuals' actions once engaged in the community. For example, after agreeing to be on a fundraising committee, committee members will typically assume the expected roles of both giving and asking others for help (Lindahl & Conley, 2002). In addition, the development of a charity brand community can be "jump started" by leveraging the strength of existing communities. For example, The United Way will approach employers, who in turn actively recruit their employees to participate in and support the campaign. This participation often extends well beyond the mere financial, with employer-sponsored teams attending and participating in special events. Not only does the United Way program benefit from the consciousness of kind and responsibility felt by members of a pre-existing community (i.e., work group), but ritualistic elements of the appeal such as the consistent timing of the campaign (e.g., Fall), specific events and the consistent use of symbols (e.g., donation thermometers) effectively serve to further strengthen the community.

CONCLUSION

The model presented here has extended the understanding of the concept of brand community introduced by Muniz and O'Guinn (2001) in a number of ways. First, the current article has tied the various markers of brand community to constructs that have well-established, valid and reliable measures. Second, the model presented here demonstrated the iterative process of brand community development, and perhaps most importantly the importance of the cognitive and experiential learning mechanisms. A discussion of current marketing practices revealed that while charitable organizations exhibit some aspects of brand community they are not cultivating the sense of community amongst supporters that is necessary to fully realize the benefits witnessed in a true brand community. However, the need to increase overall support and a desire to develop greater loyalty amongst current supporters, demonstrates the relevance of brand community to this sector.

Thus, the iterative model of brand community developed in this article is as an effective tool for charities looking to maintain or enhance supporter commitment as a means to counter current funding challenges. Charities have an opportunity to leverage brand communities to enjoy benefits similar to the increased loyalty and sales enjoyed by their for-profit counterparts. The application of the brand community model to the charity sector (arguably the most distant from those categories previously associated with brand communities underscores the belief that the proposed model can be extended to a wide range of high involvement product and services. Finally, by operationalizing the concept of brand community with existing constructs with proven validity and reliability, this article provides an important blueprint for charities looking to gain greater commitment amongst their supporters, while also making the brand community concept and its elements more accessible to researchers seeking to explore and test the brand community phenomenon. By leveraging the existing and well-defined concepts of identification, involvement and perceived sense of community, the model offers a parsimonious and executable set of propositions that enables researchers interested in brand community to measure its effects.

Future researchers are encouraged to not only test and challenge the propositions and model developed here but to extend the model to other product and service contexts in order to establish its generalizability.

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